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Chapter 1: The Beginning.

I'm face-to-face with a monster beyond my words, I cannot describe him- it aside from a few things, its body is unnaturally long, like a giant, its body is thin, like a pencil and its hands are stumps, like a stickman. I never should have come to the Ohio House of Death; would this be the end of me? Would my family think, "What happened to Nékros? He was so imaginative and smart." I don't know, I feel my mind slipping. It was a normal day, I had finished school and was heading to my friend's house for a sleepover, normally we'd eat some junk food and then head off for bed or play Truth or Dare for a little bit, where we'd do silly dares like, "Shout the spelling of, "ICUP" really loud!", or "I dare you to use that lighter over there." and, "I dare you to say to your mom, 'Do you have any condoms?'" Everyone, including me, was too stuck up in themselves to say truth, so it was essentially dare or dare. I did this partly because it was fun and silly, but mostly to make everyone think I was brave, peer pressure killed the peer, I guess. On the way to my friend's house, I run into another one of my friends called "Aitia" a bit of an odd name, but who cares? Plus, I can't say much if I wanted to. She also goes to these sleepovers and is usually the wild card, she's a huge fan of urban exploration, and in the state of Ohio, we have a lot of that stuff. I decide to strike up a conversation to break the tension, "Hey A-Aitia!"

"Hey Nékros! And for the last time, its pronounced Eye-Tay-Ah, not Ah-Tea-Ah."

"Yeah, sorry, I must've forgotten. How was school? Too bad we're now in different classes."

"Pretty good, you up for truth and dare tonight?"

"Of course I am! That's hardly a question, Aitia!"

"Yay, you pronounced it right, want a gold star?"

"Yes-!" I try to reply.

"Too bad, I gave my last one to Mrs. Carrol. Mainly because I know you hate her."

"Why am I not surprised?" I truly hated Mrs. Carrol, she always shouted and screamed if you did one thing wrong, would give you an after-school detention for being 1 minute late, overall, a bad teacher. So that was definitely to spite me, I'd know it even if she hadn't said so.

"I like teasing you, it's so funny." She says, before chuckling and stating, "And you look so cute when you're annoyed." She giggles even harder.

"H-Hey! D-Don't!" I stumble out, my cheeks going red from embarrassment, she's my crush after all, I'd do anything for her approval or even touch. She was cute, smart, funny, all the things I liked, her brown hair complimented her smooth, white skin, her brown eyes as important to me as dirt to farmers. She got me excited to say the very least. I did kind of enjoy being mocked and put down by her, but I'd never admit that.

"Aw, you look so cute with those red cheeks, let's go to Plíthos's house, shall we?"

"Uh, Y-Yeah, sure." My face was practically a tomato at this point, she was always mocking me, you'd think I would get used to it by now, but whatever, that doesn't really matter now.

"Someone's embarrassed!" She says, knowing she'll get a reaction out of me.

"Hey! Stop teasing me! Save it for the dares."

"Fine, for now you baby."

"Don't call me that!"

"Why?"

"Because- uh... I said so, okay?!"

"Whatever you say Nektós." We walk to the house in silence from then on, she doesn't start conversations and I didn't want to start one, I was too embarrassed to want to utter a word, let alone start a whole conversation. As I'm walking, I see my friend Stultus, another urban explorer who loves the dopamine rush, he's recording a video for his channel "Creepy Time" (Very original and creative, I know.) about some house called "The House of Secrets" a house I have heard a bit about. After a little while we arrive at the house.

Chapter 2: The Sleepover.

Plíthos lets us in as usual, his mom begins to order some pizza and chips for us to eat, we get the usual 2 large pepperoni pizzas with cheese stuffed crust, our favourites, we have similar tastes which makes it easier to decide what to get, thank god, I can't handle arguments, I get nervous and shut down, like loud noises do to me too. This is another thing I never told my friends. Anyway, I turn to Plíthos and say, "Hey! Thanks for letting us sleep over as usual, it's always so fun!"

"Don't mention it!" Replied Plíthos, he's always so humble, which is weird to see in a rich kid, or I guess rich parents kid, whatever, doesn't matter.

"Whatever you say bro." I say, knowing I probably need to repay him sometime.

"We will mention it, Plíthos." Says Aitia, trying to get a reaction out of Plíthos, like she does with everyone.

"Hey! I said not to! That's like..." He fumbles for his words, "Rude or something!" he says with more intensity, which makes him look worse, Aitia was always so good at making people uncomfortable and flustered. It was a special talent I suppose.

"Too bad, I would kiss it better, but I don't think you've showered today." Aitia says, knowing Plíthos was obsessed with hygiene and showering every day twice.

"You did not just-!" Plíthos tries to reply but I cut him off.

"She did, don't fight it. She knows you did; she just wants a reaction." I say to try and keep him calm.

"Aw, you're no fun, I prefer Stultus at times, he actually lets me tease people." Replies Aitia, a bit annoyed that I wouldn't let her, but she listened to me, probably because she liked me, or at least I hope she did.

“Well too bad, suck it up, you can tease us later during Truth or Dare.” I say to make her a bit happier, she is my crush and friend after all.

“Fine, but ONLY this one time, you got that?” She says, trying to sound tough, but she just comes off stubborn, when she loses her flow, she loses it hard.

“I’m sure it will be.” I reply, knowing well this will not be the last time, she always says that, but she likes me too much, again I am very much still hoping, at least that would make this somewhat worth it.

“About truth or dare, let’s do that now, it’ll be fun!” Said Plíthos quickly, wanting to get out of this conversation as quickly as possible.

“Sure! Just can we have some rules? Like last time Aitia made me sit in just my boxers, I don’t really want to do that again... You remember that, right?” I say, referring to last time that had me left in my boxers, not fun, not fun at all, it shows, I don’t usually speak about stuff like that, don’t want to seem weak and all.

“But that’s boringgg, I want to do anything I want. On second thought, that was so funny I’ll do it again.” Aitia says, annoyed she can’t do whatever she wants but hopeful she can convince us.

“Absolutely not. Especially not in front of another guy. I’d only consider that if we were like dating or something.”

“I agree with Negrós, you aren’t even like... dating, plus it’s kind of gay to be almost fully naked next to another guy, or near one... O-Of course there’s nothing wrong with that! It’s just I think he’s not gay, so it’d be odd to do it, t-that’s all...!” Says Plíthos, defensive as ever.

“We get it, don’t worry man.” I reply, knowing he hates sounding discriminatory, “Let’s go to your room to play, it’ll be good fun!”

“Okay! Let’s do this!”

Chapter 3: Dare or Dare.

We arrive upstairs in Plíthos's room, sitting on the floor in a triangle/circle shape, we decide Aitia will go first, as she was usually funny with her dares.

"Truth or Dare... Plíthos!" Aitia says, ready to say her dare.

"Dare, Aitia. Dare." Replies Plíthos, ready for his dare.

"I dare you to eat a spoon of citric acid!" Quickly replies Aitia, grinning Wildy.

"Oh, okay, that's bad but not too bad for your standards." He replies, very happy that it wasn't so bad. So, he gets up and gets a spoon and a container of pure citric acid and takes it. "Oh! That is- that is- terrible."

"It's not-" Aitia tries to speak but just bursts out laughing, unable to hold it in, but when she regains control she says, "Hah! It's not that bad! Maybe just be a little tougher."

"It is that bad!" Retorts Plíthos, speaking through a sore mouth caused by the citric acid.

"Too bad!" replies Aitia, she continues "Plus, it's your turn now! You should dare Nektros something..."

"Maybe...." Says Plíthos, hungry for revenge on me for last time. "Truth or Dare, Nektros!"

"Dare." I reply

"I dare you to... yell 'I LOVE MEN' at the top of your lungs in school tomorrow!"

"I will, but I can't do that now, so, I'll do that tomorrow." I say, slightly worried about what's going to happen tomorrow. "Now, Truth or Dare, Aitia!"

"Dare." Replies Aitia quickly.

"I dare you to yell, 'I LOVE WOMEN' tomorrow at school!" I chuckle.

"Hey! You stole from me-!" Plíthos says in response but is cut off by Aitia.

"Too bad, you did it last time, and I'll do that." She replies quickly again, but she continues with, "Truth or Dare... Nektros!"

“Dare.” I reply.

“I dare you to enter the Ohio House of Death! You have to spend at least 10 minutes in there!”

“Do you want me dead! I mean, I’ll do it, but I’ve heard stories, everyone who goes in there never goes out, and the police cover it up with a, ‘Nothing happened!’ super suspicious by the way!”

“Maybe I do, Maybe I don’t. Who knows!” Quickly responds Aitia.

“Are you scared, Nekrós? Like a baby?” Asks Plithos, trying to convince me.

“Fine! Okay, let’s go to the Ohio House of Death.” I reply.

“Good job!” She replies, trying to get me angry.

I grab a bottle of water and start to walk towards the house, getting ready to sneak in. The night is dark and cold, a new moon overhead, making it feel more unsettling, I feel like I’m being watched. When we arrive, we notice a black van parked outside, like usual, and the yellow tape surrounding the perimeter with the text, “DO NOT ENTER: CRIME SCENE.” over and over again. The house is old and decrepit, looking ancient. I walk up to the door, and I twist the knob and I’m surprised to see it’s unlocked, I realise I’m out of water, I drank it all already (but that should be fine). Then I notice the van has very tinted windows, but I can make out a person watching me, wearing government uniform. I walk inside...

Chapter 4: The House of No Eyes.

When I’m fully in, I look around and see old, decaying furniture, a big grandfather clock, the time on it is off by about an hour or so and my nose is filled with a terrible smell, one I cannot describe. Too unusual for words. Too bad for sanity. Too familiar to be unusual. So, I try to take in my surroundings, I notice the floor is dusty like an old children’s book left unread, except from a

few footsteps, I tell myself that a good thing. Someone else is here, they can help me. But then I realise those footprints don't look like any humans footprints. Or any other animal for that matter. I try to go to leave. But, as I do, I hear the click of a lock, I try the doorknob, but it's locked, I'm trapped. "Shoot". "Aitia! Aitia! This isn't funny! Unlock the stupid door!"

I notice a small black string around the twisty thing for unlocking or locking the door from the inside, but ignore it. I have bigger issues right now, plus, it's just string.

"I didn't do that! Are you okay! Get out of there!" She sounds genuinely concerned. "Are you messing wi-" Her voice suddenly cuts off, unnaturally fast, no soft fade out. A hard cut to silence. I look at the string again but move on swiftly.

Now I know I'm dead, like everyone else. Stupid door. Why didn't that man stop me? Why didn't I just say no? Stupid, stupid, stupid Nekrós!

I swallow my fear and venture further in, each footstep sounding like gunshots in this quiet house, after what feels like an eternity of walking but was more like 6 minutes, I see a blacklight on the floor. What is this doing here? I pick it up and turn it on, revealing a message on the floor, "Here's a housewarming gift. Enjoy our chat, outsider." Who wrote this? Was it meant for me? If it wasn't for me, who? And when was it written? As these thoughts enter my head, I see an arm moving behind a wall, I am suddenly overcome with dread, that hand was not human, it had no hand, just a stump, and was an unnatural pale colour, a mockery of humanity. I walk toward where I saw it, but there's nothing there, just a message left for me, it says "They never left, neither will you, outsider" Shoot, I am so dead. I need a saviour, a Salvateur, hah, I remember that foreign word from one of those Creepy Time videos made by Stultus. But that's not important right now, I need to survive, I scan my blacklight, I see a message, "Feel that migraine?" as I read it, I am hit with a migraine, what is this.... This thing?! I try to compose myself, but I see another message, "Give me your imagination, give me it... it is strong." And then another, "Call me Nekromantis, child. Or The Lurker, as many a brave knight call me." Now I'm petrified, heart beating at 100mph, and it's not slowing down. With this does come a sort of alertness, I can notice every detail, particularly that there are many water damaged rooms, none of which have messages in them, I wonder why. I continue to explore the house and stumble upon another message "In laughter is pain in pain is hatred in hatred is revenge." And another "Shylock's philosophy" and one last one "Behind you..." I turn around and-

Chapter 4.5: Thýma's Story.

Dear Diary,

12/14/18 Same old, same old, Trávma keeps on bullying me, as usual, but my new friend, The Lurker is helping me out, he may just be a face, but he loves me! And I love him! He's my best friend ever! I wish my parents would listen to me about Trávma though... But I can flex on my friends! I don't have an imaginary friend like they all do! I have a real friend! One I can feel! I had to draw him on a face, but I love him either way! This world is so bleak... But anyway! I am so much to look forward to! I have my 9th birthday tomorrow! Just 10 days before Christmas! I'm soooo excited!

End of entry.

Dear Diary,

12/16/18 My parents bought me a cool hot wheels car! And Lurker grew a neck! Soon, he'll be whole! But no one can see him, makes me sad!

End of entry.

Dear Diary,

12/26/18 My parents bought me another cool hot wheels car! And a cool track to use! And Lurker grew a chest! REALLY soon, he'll be whole! But still, no one can see him, makes me sad. Why can no one see my friend...

End of entry.

Dear Diary,

1/1/19 What did I do? My parents won't talk to me! I did everything they asked, did my chores, stopped complaining about my bully! What more do they want!? On the upside though, Lurker has grown arms! He just needs legs now! But he does not have hands yet. But that's fine!

End of entry.

Dear Diary,

1/10/19 Mommy and Daddy have started talking to me again, but they seem angry at me! Why? All they say is I have a problem, what problem?!

End of entry.

Dear Diary,

1/17/19 Lurker grew legs! He gave me a big hug and told me he'd stop those bullies! I love him so much!

End of entry.

Dear Diary,

1/28/19 How... I didn't... I never wanted this... He killed them, killed them and ripped out their teeth and put them on himself, I'm going to run away now, bye house. I'll miss you Mommy and Daddy. I'm sorry, I never wanted him to kill you, I never wanted... this. This world is so bleak.

End of entry.

Dear Diary,

??/??/?? I never wanted to kill her, I must bring my creator back, Thýma will live, she will save me, save us all, I was scared, I didn't want her to leave me... what did I do wrong? Ever since she died, I have been split, my face is a reminder of the sins I must atone for.

Chapter 5: First Contact

Now I'm back to now, I'm face-to-face with a monster beyond my words, I cannot describe him- it aside from a few things, its body is unnaturally long, like a giant, its body is thin, like a pencil.

Its hands are stumps, like a stickman. I want to die, I need to die, its face is drawn on, its split into 2 halves, stitched together, neck attached to side on my left it has human teeth, seemingly glued on with a glue gun. It's a violation of the natural order. I run. It's all I can do. I sprint fast, hearing it chase after me, its screams are a distorted mix of children's laughter and children's screams. I keep running, I end up cornered, but it runs away because of a small drop of water hitting its skin, burning it. I don't think he's a fan of water, which explains the water damage issue. I wait a bit and then start running for the kitchen, where I could fill up the empty water bottle in my pocket and throw it on him- it. On the run I hear his terrifying screams getting closer. I arrive in the kitchen, heart thumping, I quickly fill up my bottle and wait for The Lurker to come inside. The wait feels like an eternity, but it was more like 4 minutes I'd reckon. His body I am still not used to, so I recoil in just pure disgust. He screams and runs towards me...

Chapter 6: A new perspective.

[Begin audio transcript]

"And that, Mrs. Connor, is what led to the photo our drone found, after this he appears to have dropped the bottle and was killed by the lurker, he was found with his teeth ripped from his gums. This is the known work of The Lurker. His spinal cord and neck were found snapped. More analysis will be required for further details. A more detailed report should have been delivered to you on the 20th of February 2019 at the time 08:00, if it was delivered later, check for fingerprints or damaged packaging. It may have been compromised." Says Mr. Friggon, the lead researcher at the USDAA.

"The boy was foolish at least, and a criminal trespasser at worst" Mrs. Connor replies, annoyed another casualty. "Have his... accomplices been dealt with?" She asks.

"Yes, they have been brainwashed, as you call it, to remove memory of the house, and Nekrós.

"Good job."

"One question Mrs. Connor, do we know why it kills? We know its creation from the diary recovered, it talks about resurrection, but surely death is not required?"

“That is classified information. Stay in your place, Mr. Friggon. All you need to know is you’re doing a good job currently, and I like you. I’d hate to have to... dispose of you, if you know what I mean.” She says coldly.

“Y-Yes Mrs. Connor, I understand. Please don’t kill me, I’m only 23...”

“I won’t have to if you stay in line, Dr. Minni wants to see you, by the way, something about Experiment 1003 and needing ‘help’ with the final stage of creation, the child, Subject 1001 is refusing to use her imagination to create it. Stupid child.”

“Of course, Mrs. Connor, and I’ll head to that right away!”

“Good job, I will check up on incident 0004. The death is the most brutal we have on file. I want to know the motivations of ‘The Lurker’ I want to see if we can use him as a weapon. He is the blueprint after all, we’ve just been trying to recreate his perfection.”

[End audio transcript]

Chapter 7: Experiment 1004.

[Begin audio transcript]

“Hey! Come over here!” Says Dr. Minni, she’s the sort of woman who’s not a big fan of her position. She hates how most kids are killed after use, the mind-clearing technology not working on the undeveloped mind, the ones who aren’t killed live in solitude. A fate worse than death.

“What’s wrong?” Replies Mr. Friggon

“She’s not cooperating, most kids listen to you, so I thought I’d give it a shot, I don’t want her to be tortured for non-compliance.” She shivers at the thought, remembering the screams of the others. “Please do your best, okay?”

“I will try my best, I don’t know how Mrs. Connor can sleep at all! She’s a psychopath.”

“Me neither. But she’s not a psychopath, you cannot control a psychopath, she just has psychopathic tendencies.”

“To-may-to, to-mah-to, it’s a small difference.” He replies, but quickly gets back on track, “W-Where is she? And what’s her name and background? I need this information to come off as friendly and wanting to help!”

“She’s a 9 year old girl called Emily, she grew up in poverty so her parents had to sell her to us so they could pay rent, poor thing, she loves apples and oranges, she had 2 friends back in her school, James and Emma, we don’t know why she only liked them though, she hated everyone else.”

“Okay... I need to do this.”

He walks over to the pod Emily is in.

“Hey sport! How are you doing!”

“Terrible! Let me out of here! I don’t wanna I don’t wanna I don’t wanna I don’t wanna- “Emily retorts, clearly her mind is breaking.

“Hey, shhh, it’s OK, I’m here for you.” He replies, trying to sooth her. “Just do what that kind lady asks and you’ll be OK! We’ll even let you see Emma and James again.”

“R-Really?”

“Really.”

“O-Okay then.”

“Right, that’s good, I’ll leave you with the kind lady now!”

“O-Okay. Just let me see my friends and my mommy, I miss them...”

He walks back to Dr. Minni.

“God, I feel so bad. She’s never going to see her friends again. But I’d rather lie than have her tortured. Waterboarding is not fun from what I’ve heard.”

“None of us like it, or at least most of us, poor things don’t know what’s going to happen to them, but there nothing we can do but watch and cry. If we quit, well that would be a mistake, as you’d know by now.”

“I guess so. I’ve only been here 2 years, but I’ve seen 200+ kids die. I hate it...”